



PROGRESS REPORT

Lesotho: progress report, August 2025 – August 2026

Edition of 2026-08-26 · 69 systems and instruments tracked

Of 69 systems and instruments on this place's ledger, 33 changed position between 2025-08-01 and 2026-08-26, 15 did not, 19 carry no stated baseline, and 2 are **Not held** at both ends.

SUMMARY OF THE PERIOD · GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · GEOPOLITICS · WHERE THE RECORD IS THIN

Shape check, run before the comparison: 60 sources for this place in the window — 12 in the earlier half (2025-08 to 2026-02), 48 in the later (2026-03 to 2026-08). The earlier half of the window is thin: this is a shorter comparison wearing a longer label, and the movement below rests mostly on the later half.

Movement values. *Advanced* — a system entered service, a stage was completed or an instrument was made. *Stalled* — a stated target passed without delivery. *Regressed* — an instrument was withdrawn or neutralised, or a measured position worsened. *Closed* — the programme ended. *No change* — the position at both ends is the same. *Baseline not held* — the base carries no position at the start of the period, so no movement can be stated. A value may carry a qualifying clause after a comma, as in *Advanced, slipped*.

Summary of the period

The twelve months to 10 August 2026 added instruments and institutions and left the operating systems where they were. Three policies were signed, an interim response team and a cybersecurity forum were created, a data-centre project was approved, and a wallet-based investment product opened. The national switch, the mobile money platforms, the identity system and the social registry's management information system all end the period in the position they began it in.

The instruments that arrived are mostly unreadable from here. The [three policies signed on 12 June 2026](#) are held as reported signings and not as texts; the [bilateral health agreement with the United States](#) was signed in December 2025 and its related data-sharing instrument has not been published; the National Cybersecurity Strategy invoked at the [CSIRT launch](#) is not held. What can be compared over this period is therefore mostly the existence of things rather than their content.

The one position that did not move and would have been expected to is data protection: the Act has been in force since 2011 and its [Commission was still unappointed in March 2026](#).

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Broadband Infrastructure Sharing Policy	Not signed	Signed; no implementation instrument or regulator guidance on record	ADVANCED

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Data Management Policy	Not signed	Signed, framed as a privacy, security and ethical-use framework	ADVANCED
National AI Policy	Not signed	Signed, covering responsible AI in health, education and public administration	ADVANCED
National AI Strategy	Did not exist	Being drafted at the same five-day Maseru workshop as the data-centre blueprint, organised by the communications ministry with the United Nations in Lesotho, and intended as the framework for deploying artificial intelligence; the deputy prime minister's keynote asked for capability assessment, safeguards, infrastructure, policy and human capacity to be settled before investment is scaled	ADVANCED
National Digital Policy 2024	In force	In force, unamended	NO CHANGE
National Digital Transformation Strategy: Agenda 2030	In force	In force, unamended	NO CHANGE

Legislation and regulation

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Cybercrime Bill	BASELINE NOT HELD	Split out of the Computer Crime and Cybersecurity Bill and awaiting National Assembly approval, on no published timetable	<i>Baseline not held</i>
Cybersecurity Bill	BASELINE NOT HELD	Split out of the Computer Crime and Cybersecurity Bill, intended to build the institutions protecting critical digital infrastructure, and awaiting National Assembly approval	<i>Baseline not held</i>

Data protection

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Bilateral health agreement with the United States and its data-sharing instrument	Did not exist	Signed; the State Department briefly published a subset of the memoranda in March 2026 and then removed public access, and the related data-sharing agreements have not been published	ADVANCED
Data Protection Act 2011	In force, unamended	In force, unamended as at 2026-03-23	NO CHANGE
Data Protection Commission	Provided for in law, unappointed	Provided for in law, unappointed as at 2026-03-23	NO CHANGE

Regional collaboration

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
50-in-5 DPI campaign membership	A member	A member; no campaign milestone reported for Lesotho since	NO CHANGE
African Union Data Policy Framework domestication	Assessment convened; no output held	Assessment convened; no readiness assessment, legislative review or resulting instrument is held	NO CHANGE

Standards

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
LCA Quality of Service Rules (Legal Notice 41 of 2023)	BASELINE NOT HELD	In force under Legal Notice No. 41 of 2023, prescribing minimum quality-of-service standards for voice, data, postal and courier licensees across service accessibility, integrity and retainability, with two published schedules of measurable parameters	<i>Baseline not held</i>

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Telecoms quality-of-service compliance	BASELINE NOT HELD	75% overall compliance across twelve general parameters for the two mobile network operators in the year to 2025-03-31, missing on disconnection-complaint resolution time and mobile order-completion time; Q3 2025/26 drive-testing across three Maseru clusters in November 2025 found mean LTE download speeds of 2.88-2.95 Mbps against a 25 Mb/s target and unsuccessful call ratios of 2.6-6.2% against a 2% ceiling	<i>Baseline not held</i>

Public debate and participation in policymaking

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Allegation of interference in regulator appointments	Did not exist	The outgoing chief licensing officer at the communications authority accused the government of political interference in the regulator's senior appointments, alleging at a media briefing reported on 22 August 2026 that the communications minister pressed the board to re-advertise his post rather than renew the five-year contract that expired on 31 May 2026, and that the universal service fund's executive secretary was removed in the same way; the minister said she has no role in recruiting the authority's managers, and the authority declined to comment	ADVANCED
Public digital services experience survey	BASELINE NOT HELD	Open to citizens, covering access, usability, trust and skills gaps across online applications, digital payments and health and education platforms, as part of a donor-backed digital readiness assessment	<i>Baseline not held</i>

Three instruments were made and none can be read. The [broadband infrastructure sharing, data management and AI policies](#) were signed on 12 June 2026, and the texts are not held.

The most consequential governance change of the period is one the record can describe only from outside. Lesotho [signed a bilateral health agreement with the United States in December 2025](#) stated at US\$364m; a [FOIA complaint of 2 April 2026](#) records that the State Department briefly published a subset of the memoranda in March 2026 and then removed public access, and that the related data-sharing agreements have not been published at all.

Nothing moved on the domestic data-protection framework, and nothing moved on regional alignment: the [AUDA-NEPAD readiness workshop](#) of July 2025 has produced no assessment, legislative review or instrument that is held here, and Lesotho's [50-in-5 membership](#) has no reported milestone since 2024.

Finance

Domestic budget appropriations and expenditure

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Domestic budget appropriation for digital transformation	BASELINE NOT HELD	M381.1 million allocated to the ICT sector for 2025/26, naming a Government Security Operations Centre (GovSOC), a Government of Lesotho Enterprise Architecture and Interoperability Framework, a completed LEMOFI fibre feasibility study, 17 operational base tower stations and a 96km Roma-Thaba-Tseka fibre stretch underway	<i>Baseline not held</i>

MoUs and other agreements

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Development-partner support for the data blueprint	BASELINE NOT HELD	Named as supporters at the first workshop; no programme document, terms of reference or amount is held	<i>Baseline not held</i>

No domestic budget appropriation for digital transformation is held at either end of the period: no budget speech, estimates volume or appropriation act naming a MICSTI vote or a digital-transformation budget line is on record for 2024/25 or later.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Lesotho Metropolitan Fibre Distribution Network (LEMOFI)	Did not exist	Feasibility study completed, laying groundwork for expanding high-speed broadband connectivity across major towns; construction not reported	ADVANCED
Starlink satellite internet service	Live through T-Connect, the sole reseller	Live through T-Connect, and reported also carried over Vodacom low-earth-orbit backhaul (2026-01)	ADVANCED
Vodacom Lesotho mobile network	A network upgrade pledged at the group chief executive's visit (2025-08)	1.21m customers and 85% market share, 422 base stations of which 101 are solar, and 2G 97%, 3G 98% and 4G 96% coverage (2026-06)	ADVANCED
Econet Telecom Lesotho 5G network	149 5G sites on 700MHz (2025-06)	149 5G sites on 700MHz; no later figure held	NO CHANGE
Econet Wi-Fi Plus fixed-mobile convergence service	In service	In service; nothing later on record	NO CHANGE
Starlink operating licence	Granted, and contested over 100% foreign ownership	Granted; nothing later on record resolves the local-shareholding objection	NO CHANGE

Data Storage

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Project Kobong hydropower and AI data centre	Did not exist	Approved, on a binding Memorandum of Agreement of 4 June 2026 covering at least 1,200MW of pumped storage and a green-powered AI data centre at Mokhotlong, conditional on feasibility, financing, permitting and definitive agreements, with construction targeted for 2029	ADVANCED
National data-centre implementation roadmap	Not held	In drafting at a five-day, six-ministry workshop that opened in Maseru on 17 August 2026 and runs to 21 August, organised by the communications ministry with the United Nations in Lesotho and coordinated by the UN Office for Digital and Emerging Technologies, alongside a National AI Strategy drafted in the same room; it covers data governance, skills, compute, energy, cooling, financing and implementation choices, and builds on the artificial-intelligence, data-management and broadband policies the government validated in draft in January 2025	BASELINE NOT HELD

Energy

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Electricity generation against domestic demand	BASELINE NOT HELD	About 72MW installed against about 209MW of domestic demand, with 438 of the 970 GWh consumed in 2024 imported	<i>Baseline not held</i>

Technical Capacity

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Mohale's Hoek government data centre	BASELINE NOT HELD	Tier III facility under the e-Government Infrastructure Project, near-complete pending its power station, designed as 100km-separated backup to the Finance Ministry's Maseru data centre; no later source confirms completion or operational status	<i>Baseline not held</i>

Cybersecurity

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Government Chief Information Security Officer	Did not exist	Appointed, reported as the first such post across government	ADVANCED
Interim national CSIRT (LesComCSIRT)	Did not exist	Operating on an interim basis, ahead of the statute intended to establish it	ADVANCED
National Cybersecurity Forum	Did not exist	Standing, spanning government, industry, regulators, financial institutions and telecommunications providers	ADVANCED
National Security Operations Centre	Budgeted for establishment, per the 2025/26 budget speech (2025-02-19)	Reported being stood up; no host, operator or date published	ADVANCED

The cybersecurity estate went from nothing on record to four named institutions inside two days of July 2026. The [interim CSIRT and the National Cybersecurity Forum](#) were launched on 29 July, a Chief Information Security Officer was appointed across government, and a Security Operations Centre was reported being stood up. The two bills that would put the response team on a statutory footing [await National Assembly approval](#), so the institutional position at the end of the period is ahead of the legal one.

The data-centre position moved from nothing to an [approved project](#) on 31 July 2026, on an agreement signed on 4 June that is conditional on feasibility, financing, permitting and definitive agreements, with construction targeted for 2029. Nothing else is on the record: no government hosting arrangement and no capacity figure for any national facility.

The networks moved less than the announcements suggest. Vodacom Lesotho's published position went from a pledged upgrade in August 2025 to [1.21m customers and 85% market share in June 2026](#), with 422 base stations of which 101 are solar; Econet's last published network figure remains [149 5G sites on 700MHz from June 2025](#). Starlink was already retailing when the period opened and the [objection to its full foreign ownership](#) is where it was.

DPI

Data Exchange

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Government of Lesotho Enterprise Architecture and Interoperability Framework	Did not exist	In development; aimed at improving government efficiency and digital service delivery and avoiding fragmented, costly ICT infrastructure deployment across government; no further detail published	ADVANCED
X-Road government interoperability platform	Once-only information exchange named as a priority in the India memorandum, with no platform on record (2025-07)	Presented as one of three systems under development; no go-live date published	ADVANCED

Digital Identity and CRVS

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
MOSIP-based integrated national digital ID	Digital ID pilots begun under the India memorandum, with no platform named (2025-07)	A 2026 work plan signed with UNICEF to build a MOSIP-based national ID ecosystem covering passport and ID renewal, biometric registration and proof-of-life verification	ADVANCED
Digital birth registration under Ntlafatsa Bana	In operation, with 20,000 Child Grants Programme beneficiaries on digital grant payments	In operation; no later enrolment figure is held	NO CHANGE
National Identification System	In operation; the most recent account held is the 2022 World Bank case study	In operation; no later coverage, enrolment or performance figure is held	NO CHANGE
Digital service-ID pilot	BASELINE NOT HELD	Testing-phase pilot of about 10,000 participants; registration requires a valid national identity document, a registered SIM card and biometric registration; no vendor, legal basis or evaluation criteria stated	Baseline not held

Digital Payments and Fintech

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
M-Pesa Lesotho (VCL Financial Services)	Operated inside Vodacom Lesotho	Operating as VCL Financial Services, a separately constituted entity, with 14,000 agents (2026-06)	ADVANCED
Renminbi settlement access through CIPS	Did not exist	Available through Standard Bank, one of five markets added beyond South Africa	ADVANCED
Revenue Services Lesotho tax e-payment integration	Did not exist	Live for company tax, PAYE, VAT and customs duties over USSD, internet banking and the bank's mobile application	ADVANCED
Tsetela wallet investment service	Did not exist	Live over USSD on *200#, from M50 for individual M-Pesa customers and M300 for Mokhatlo group-savings customers, with STANLIB Lesotho licensed by the Central Bank of Lesotho	ADVANCED
EcoCash mobile money	In service on the platform migrated in October 2024, with group savings, payroll and fraud detection integrated	Unchanged; wallet interest payouts were stated as forthcoming and nothing later is held	NO CHANGE

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
LeSwitch national payment switch	Instant payments (2022), ATM localisation (2024-10) and point-of-sale localisation (2025-05) live across four commercial banks	Unchanged; e-commerce and retail were named as next and nothing later is held	NO CHANGE

Registries

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
NISSA social registry	Holding data on more than 90% of households, categorised by vulnerability	Same coverage, with a child-centred redesign piloted in Mafeteng District under the Universal DPI Safeguards Framework	ADVANCED

Sectoral management information systems

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Foundational Literacy and Numeracy Dashboard	Did not exist	Under construction for Grades 1-3, with tablets for principals in 300 project schools and solar power in 25 cluster learning spaces	ADVANCED
National monitoring and evaluation reporting capacity	Did not exist	A consultancy advertised to strengthen the national AIDS commission capacity to coordinate national monitoring and evaluation reporting	ADVANCED
MISSA social-assistance management information system	Procurement issued in 2024, with no award or delivery on record	Procurement issued in 2024, with no award or delivery on record	NO CHANGE
Decision Support System for planning and budgeting	BASELINE NOT HELD	Presented as under development; no scope, host or date published	Baseline not held

Other GovTech and e-Gov

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
E-Parliament system	Did not exist	Implemented, described as marking a key milestone in modernising legislative processes; no further detail published	ADVANCED
eGovernment Infrastructure Project Phase II	An African Development Bank commitment of US\$13.95m (2019), with US\$16.5m disbursed and the project ending in 2026	Digital Outreach Studio launched under the project (2026-06)	ADVANCED
National Data Value Creation Blueprint	Did not exist	Drafting opened at a first consultative workshop; no text exists	ADVANCED
Separate government ICT agency	BASELINE NOT HELD	Announced; no enabling instrument, scope or date published	Baseline not held

Payments gained products, not rails. LeSwitch ends the period exactly where it started – instant transfers, ATM and point-of-sale transactions cleared domestically across [four commercial banks](#), with e-commerce and retail still named as next. What changed is what runs on top: Vodacom's mobile money was [reconstituted as VCL Financial Services](#) in March 2026 and now runs 14,000 agents, [Tsetela](#) opened investment from M50 in July 2026, [tax e-payment](#) went live in February 2026, and [renminbi settlement](#) became available in July. EcoCash is unchanged on the platform it migrated to in October 2024.

Identity advanced on paper. The digital-ID position opened the period as pilots under the [India memorandum](#) with no platform named and closes it with a [2026 work plan with UNICEF](#) for a MOSIP-based system; the National Identification System that is actually in operation has no account later than 2022, so no coverage or enrolment figure can be compared at either end.

The interoperability layer moved from a stated priority to two named systems — X-Road and a Decision Support System, both [presented as work in progress in February 2026](#) with no go-live date. Drafting of a [National Data Value Creation Blueprint](#) opened in July 2026 and no text exists. A [learning-data dashboard](#) entered construction, and satellite connectivity for [schools and clinics](#) began in January 2026. The social registry's management information system did not move at all: its [procurement was issued in 2024](#) and no award or delivery is on record.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Maseru City Council Construction Permit Automation System	BASELINE NOT HELD	Live at mcc-cp.org.ls , built by Computer Business Solutions (Lesotho) with Web Masters Kenya under World Bank Private Sector Competitiveness Project funding: online application, document upload, staged review, SMS/email notifications, auto-generated invoices and digital permit issue	<i>Baseline not held</i>

Rural digital data capture

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
T-Connect Impact school and clinic connectivity	Did not exist	Operating, following the first community hotspots handed over at Matsieng, Thaba Bosiu and Mokhotlong in September 2025	ADVANCED

Technology

AI

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
National AI Academy	Did not exist	Proposed in a signed memorandum; no timetable, governance structure, curriculum or host institution is named	ADVANCED

ICT Industry

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Private-sector cloud and cybersecurity capacity	BASELINE NOT HELD	One executive workshop on record, on ransomware, cloud security, data sovereignty and immutable backup	<i>Baseline not held</i>

Innovation ecosystem

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
UNDP-Econet memorandum of understanding	A standing partnership signed in 2020 and amended in 2022	Renewed across three pillars - digital transformation, connectivity and AI; the innovation ecosystem; and MSME digital entrepreneurship - with no amount, term or deliverable stated	ADVANCED

Artificial intelligence went from statements to one signed institutional commitment. The [memorandum Econet Telecom Lesotho and UNDP signed on 28 July 2026](#) renews a partnership first signed in 2020 and amended in 2022 and names a National AI Academy; it states no amount, term or deliverable, and nothing names a timetable, curriculum or host institution for the Academy. That is the first institutional AI commitment on the record, and it is a memorandum rather than a policy.

The external relationships diverged. The [India memorandum](#) of July 2025 has produced no recorded deliverable in the twelve months since. The American relationship produced the largest project on the ledger, and the [US Embassy states](#) it facilitated US\$7.3bn of commercial partnerships over eighteen months, which is its own figure.

Capacity

Training and skills

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
AI Skills Development Programme	Did not exist	Running, reported as Lesotho's first digital-entrepreneurship and AI-tools training	ADVANCED
Vodacom and AWS digital-skills training	Did not exist	Pledged; nothing on record has been delivered in the twelve months since	ADVANCED, A PLEDGE ONLY
Government digital-literacy training in all ten districts	BASELINE NOT HELD	Running across all ten districts; no participant numbers published	Baseline not held

Research institutions

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Government and National University of Lesotho DPI collaboration	BASELINE NOT HELD	One joint review on record; no research programme, funding or output published	Baseline not held

Inclusion

Access to services

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Broadband coverage against actual internet use	BASELINE NOT HELD	100% broadband coverage against about 50% regular internet use, stated by MICSTI at the UN Global Dialogue on AI Governance (2026-07)	Baseline not held
Cross-border remittance channel to South Africa	BASELINE NOT HELD	Migrant workers moving from banks to fintechs such as Mukuru as South African remittance and banking rules tightened (2026-06)	Baseline not held

The government's stated measure of the access problem — [100% broadband coverage against about 50% regular internet use](#) — was given in July 2026, and the base carries no comparable figure from the start of the period, so the gap cannot be shown to have narrowed or widened.

Training moved once. The [AI Skills Development Programme](#) with the US Embassy began in June 2026, and [digital-literacy training](#) is reported across all ten districts without participant numbers. The digital-skills training [pledged with AWS in August 2025](#) has nothing recorded against it in the twelve months since.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
US commercial diplomacy in the digital and energy sectors	Not stated	Stated by the US Embassy at US\$7.3bn of commercial partnerships facilitated in Lesotho over the previous eighteen months, of which Kobong is the largest	ADVANCED

India activities

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Lesotho-India digital public infrastructure memorandum	Signed, naming digital ID, a unified payment environment and once-only information exchange as the year's three priorities	Unchanged; no deliverable, workstream or funding under it is on record	NO CHANGE

Where the record is thin

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT	LAST PROBED
National Cybersecurity Strategy	The text of the strategy the minister invoked at the LesComCSIRT launch, or an official statement of its adoption date, version and targets. The 2022 Cybersecurity Capacity Maturity Model review states Lesotho had no official national strategy.	2026-08-10
National open data portal	A government open-data portal or published open-data policy for Lesotho, or an official statement that none exists.	2026-08-10

Two of these absences have been searched for and stayed empty across the period rather than newly appearing. The National Cybersecurity Strategy was invoked again at the July 2026 launch and remains without a published location, and the digital service-ID pilot [reported to have begun with 10,000 participants](#) has produced no enrolment or coverage figure.

The others are absences the period did not create and did not close: where government systems are hosted, whether any municipal digital service exists, whether interoperability or quality-of-service standards have been published, whether an open-data portal exists, and what the state appropriates for digital transformation.

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This is a dated edition and is not revised after publication. If a figure here has moved, the current edition will say so.